The Private Markets Forum

Infrastructure At The Edge Of Scale

SURVEY FINDINGS | MARCH 2026 | PRIVATE CREDIT



What Private Credit Needs To Build Next. The Industry Has Scaled In Assets Faster Than It Has Scaled In Infrastructure — This Survey Of Senior Operators Puts Data Behind That Thesis.

The five pillars of this survey:

I Scaling constraints
II LP pressure
III Modernization
IV Build list
V At scale

Across every firm size, the industry converges on the same core problem: a unified data model that does not yet exist.

Executive Summary

Private credit has scaled in assets faster than it has scaled in infrastructure. This survey confirms that thesis with data.

We surveyed senior operators across the AUM spectrum — from sub-$1B emerging managers to $50B+ global platforms — with deliberate emphasis on the largest and most operationally complex firms in the market. 42% of respondents manage $50B+ in AUM. These are the platforms where infrastructure failure has the largest consequences, and where the findings carry the most weight.

Across this sample, the industry converges on the same core problem: a unified data model that does not yet exist. LP pressure is rising everywhere. AI adoption is accelerating across the board. But where the infrastructure actually breaks, and how firms respond, depends on where they sit on the growth curve.

This report presents aggregate findings across five pillars: the Scaling Constraints Map, the LP Pressure Index, the Modernization Trajectory, the Build List, and What Breaks at Scale — the segmented view showing how constraints shift from people to process to architecture as platforms scale.

42%	45%	61%
$50B+ AUM	DATA MODEL	AI IN PRODUCTION

Five findings define the landscape:

01 The Data Model Is The Bottleneck

45% of respondents named a unified data model across strategies and systems as the single operational problem they would most want solved. Cross-system integration is the #1 weighted scaling constraint, appearing across all three ranking tiers more than any other item.

02 What Breaks Depends On Where You Are

Emerging firms are constrained by people. Mid-market firms are constrained by process. Large platforms are constrained by architecture. The demand for a unified data model is universal across all three tiers, but the path to get there looks different at each stage. Firms starting today can build clean from the outset. Firms at scale are retrofitting systems that were never designed to work together.

03 LP Pressure Is Accelerating

74% report that LP and ODD pressure has increased in the past two years, with 37% calling the increase significant. The top demands are faster reporting, bespoke templates, and real-time data access. LPs are pushing GPs from document delivery to data delivery.

04 The Industry Is Building

71% of respondents have built internal tools because nothing on the market fits. Core system satisfaction averages just 2.8 out of 5. The vendor landscape is underserving the market.

05 AI Has Hit Production

61% of firms now run AI in production for at least one workflow. Document extraction is the consensus entry point, but the pipeline extends into underwriting, covenant compliance, and monitoring. The hybrid model (vendor + internal customization) is the dominant deployment approach.

Respondent Profile

The survey targeted senior operators at institutional-scale private credit platforms — the people closest to the infrastructure challenges this research targets, at the firms where those challenges matter most.

The respondent base is intentionally concentrated in technology and operations leadership: CTOs, Heads of Data, and senior operations decision-makers who own the problems documented in this report. The sample is designed to reflect the firms operating at scale.

61% of respondents manage $15B+ in AUM. A meaningful cohort of sub-$1B emerging managers (21%) provides analytical contrast across growth stages — firms building infrastructure from scratch alongside platforms managing the consequences of rapid growth.

47%
CTO / HEAD OF TECHNOLOGY

61%
$15B+ AUM

42%
$50B+ AUM

Firm Size Distribution

AUM RANGE	COUNT	SHARE
$50B+	16	42%
< $1B	8	21%
$5–$15B	6	16%
$15–$30B	4	11%
$30–$50B	3	8%
$1–$5B	1	3%
All respondents	**38**	**100%**

The bimodal distribution provides valuable analytical contrast. Infrastructure challenges manifest differently at scale versus in growth mode. The largest platforms contend with multi-strategy complexity and the weight of legacy systems. Emerging managers face the greenfield question of what to build first.



Delegates in conversation between sessions

Credits: The Private Markets Forum Team



Panellists on stage at the Private Markets Technology Summit, London

Credits: The Private Markets Forum Team

Primary Roles

ROLE	COUNT	SHARE
CTO / Head of Engineering / Technology	18	47%
Managing Director / Partner (Investment)	6	16%
Head of Data / Analytics	4	11%
Head of Portfolio Operations / Monitoring	2	5%
COO / Head of Operations	1	3%
CFO / Finance / Controller	1	3%
General Counsel / CLO	1	3%
Other C-Suite / Senior Leadership	5	13%
All respondents	38	100%

Respondents represent firms running diverse strategies, with significant overlap. 66% are active in asset-based finance. 63% run direct lending. 58% manage multi-strategy portfolios. This multistrategy complexity is itself a driver of infrastructure challenges.

Strategy Coverage

STRATEGY	FIRMS ACTIVE	SHARE
Asset-based finance (ABF) / NAV / specialty	25	66%
Direct lending / corporate credit	24	63%
Structured credit / CLO / opportunistic	22	58%
Multi-strategy private credit	22	58%
BDCs / Interval Funds	18	47%
Real estate credit	16	42%

The industry remains in aggressive growth mode. 74% of respondents expect to grow AUM by 1.25x or more within the next 24–36 months, with nearly one in four targeting 2x+ growth. This growth trajectory is the engine that exposes infrastructure gaps.

Growth Trajectory

EXPECTED GROWTH	COUNT	SHARE
1.25–2.0x AUM	19	50%
2.0x+ AUM	9	24%
< 1.25x AUM	4	11%
Uncertain	4	11%
Flat or contracting	2	5%
All respondents	38	100%

Technology budgets are expanding to match. 79% of respondents expect to increase technology spending this year. The balance has shifted toward moderate increases (up to 20%), suggesting the industry is moving from one-time platform builds to sustained operational investment.

Technology Investment

BUDGET DIRECTION	COUNT	SHARE
Increase moderately (up to 20%)	20	53%
Increase significantly (20%+)	10	26%
Flat or slight decrease	4	11%
Don't know	3	8%
Decrease significantly	1	3%
All respondents	38	100%

The staffing picture underscores the talent constraint identified later in this report. 58% of firms report investment-weighted staffing ratios of 3:1 or higher, meaning investment teams significantly outnumber operations and technology staff. Only 11% are operations-weighted. The operational side of the house is structurally understaffed relative to the complexity it manages.

Staffing Ratios

STAFFING RATIO	COUNT	SHARE
Heavily investment-weighted (>5:1)	12	32%
Investment-weighted (3:1 to 5:1)	10	26%
Balanced (1.5:1 to 3:1)	6	16%
Operations-weighted (<1.5:1)	4	11%
Don't know / prefer not to say	6	16%
All respondents	**38**	**100%**

Base: 38 respondents. Shares are rounded, so columns may not total exactly 100%. Strategy coverage is multi-select, so those shares sum above 100%.

The Scaling Constraints Map

The core research question is simple: what breaks when you scale? We asked respondents to identify and rank the operational constraints most likely to fracture as they add AUM, asset classes, and investor types. The answers reveal an industry whose primary challenge is not any single system failure. It is a fundamental inability to connect systems into a coherent whole.

I

Scaling constraints

II

LP pressure

III

Modernization

IV

Build list

V

At scale

Analysis: The Three Dominant Constraints

01 Cross-System Data Model / Integrations

Cross-system data integration leads the weighted ranking despite not being the most common single #1 choice. Its strength comes from breadth: 53% of respondents placed it in their top three. This is the constraint that touches everything. When firms cannot unify data across portfolio systems, accounting platforms, and reporting tools, every downstream function requires manual intervention to bridge the gaps.

02 Talent (Hiring/Retaining Ops & Tech Staff)

Talent is the most frequently cited #1 constraint (24%), reflecting an industry where operations and technology roles are chronically understaffed. With 58% of firms reporting investment-weighted staffing ratios of 3:1 or above, the operational side of the house is being asked to do more with less.

03 LP Reporting (Frequency, Granularity, Bespoke)

LP reporting rounds out the top three. Notably, it ranks as a #1 or #2 constraint for 32% of respondents. This is not a back-office nuisance. It is a scaling bottleneck that directly affects fundraising capacity and LP retention.

From The Interviews: What Integration Actually Looks Like

Follow-up interviews brought these constraints to life. At one $50B+ platform, the integration challenge is visceral: people have become the connective tissue between systems.

> “Too much of the day is spent connecting dots between systems via email and spreadsheets, rather than going out and finding the next deal or asking whether we're picking the right ones.”
>
> — Product & Strategy Leader, $50B+ Multi-Strategy Platform

The same respondent traced the root cause to security master inconsistency across merged entities. Every downstream system derives its information from security master, so any inconsistency there cascades. His observation: he knows you need 8 fields to settle a bond on the street, so why does the internal system require 35? Legacy complexity has layered requirements on top of requirements, and no one has gone back to simplify.

On the talent constraint, a Managing Director at a mid-market multi-strategy firm confirmed the pattern. Private credit is growing, the economy is at full employment, and the pool of people with relevant experience is genuinely limited. Technology adoption, in his telling, is partly a response to the talent shortage: if you cannot hire your way out of the volume problem, you find tools that let existing people handle more.

A different perspective came from the Head of Credit Product at a major technology platform, who reframed data ingestion as structural rather than solvable. Private borrowers do not file publicly. The data arrives in different formats with different levels of availability. His point was sharp:

> "The complexity premium that private credit investors earn is partly compensation for navigating exactly this kind of data complexity. Things can be improved on the margin, but structural messiness is intrinsic to the asset class."
>
> — Head of Credit Product, Global Technology Platform

#1	71%	2.8/5
CROSS-SYSTEM	HAVE BUILT INTERNAL TOOLS	CORE SYSTEM SATISFACTION

Respondents ranked their top three scaling constraints. The weighted scoring reveals cross-system data integration as the single most pervasive constraint. It appears consistently across all three ranking tiers, reflecting its impact on every downstream process.

Top Scaling Break Points (Weighted Ranking)

CONSTRAINT	WEIGHTED	#1	#2	#3
Cross-system data model / integrations	38	6	6	8
Talent (hiring/retaining ops & tech staff)	34	9	2	3
LP reporting (frequency, granularity, bespoke)	32	6	6	2
Reconciliation (positions, cash, accruals)	23	4	4	3
Portfolio monitoring cadence	23	3	6	2
Data ingestion from borrowers/agents	19	4	2	3
Multi-asset straight-through processing	15	2	3	3
Availability of quality market data	15	2	3	3
Portfolio accounting / ABOR / asset servicing	12	1	3	3
Covenant tracking & compliance	9	0	2	5
ODD readiness (controls, evidence, audit)	8	1	1	3

Methodology: Weighted score assigns 3 points for a #1 ranking, 2 for #2, and 1 for #3. Maximum possible = 114.

We asked respondents to identify where they rely most on manual workarounds today. The weighted results show that manual work clusters around four areas, each representing a significant automation opportunity.

Where Manual Work Concentrates

WORKAROUND AREA	WEIGHTED	#1	#2	#3
Valuation / mark-to-market process	40	7	7	5
Data ingestion / spreading / extraction	38	9	2	7
Cross-system integrations / data stitching	31	6	4	5
LP reporting / ODD response process	30	7	3	3
Reconciliation (cash, payments, positions)	22	2	6	4
Due diligence / IC memo workflow	17	1	5	4
Covenant compliance workflow	14	1	4	3
Deal pipeline / CRM / coverage tracking	13	2	2	3
Monitoring / alerts / exceptions	12	1	3	3
Portfolio accounting / ABOR	11	2	2	1

Valuation and data ingestion together account for the heaviest manual burden. These are the two areas where the gap between data volume and system capability is widest. They are also the areas where AI deployment is concentrating, as documented in Section III.

71% of respondents have built internal tools because nothing on the market fits. The areas where firms are building reveal the vendor landscape's most acute gaps.

The Internal Build Response

AREA	FIRMS BUILDING	SHARE OF BUILDERS (N=27)
Portfolio management / allocation	13	48%
Data ingestion / validation	12	44%
Pipeline / deal tracking	11	41%
Data model / warehouse / BI	10	37%
LP reporting / portals	8	30%
Covenant tracking	5	19%
Reconciliation	4	15%
Monitoring / alerting	4	15%
Underwriting / IC workflow	3	11%
Valuation / pricing	3	11%

Current satisfaction with core systems remains low. The average rating for core loan and portfolio systems is 2.8 out of 5. Pipeline and CRM systems fare slightly better at 3.2 out of 5. Neither score reflects confidence in the current vendor landscape.

System Satisfaction: A Market Underserved

RATING (1–5)	CORE LOAN/PORTFOLIO SYSTEM	PIPELINE / CRM SYSTEM
1 (Very Dissatisfied)	4 (11%)	2 (5%)
2	8 (21%)	6 (16%)
3	18 (47%)	16 (42%)
4	7 (18%)	12 (32%)
5 (Very Satisfied)	1 (3%)	2 (5%)

Key signal: 47% of respondents rate their core portfolio system at the midpoint (3/5). This is not satisfaction. It is tolerance. The market is enduring mediocre tools because better alternatives do not exist or are too costly to switch to.

The LP Pressure Index

Limited partners are no longer passive recipients of quarterly reports. They are active drivers of GP infrastructure modernization. This section captures what LPs are demanding, how that pressure is changing, and where GPs are struggling to respond.

I
Scaling constraints

II
LP pressure

III
Modernization

IV
Build list

V
At scale

01 The Reporting Trifecta

Three reporting-related demands dominate the LP pressure landscape, and they reinforce each other. LPs want reports faster, they want them customized to their templates, and they want selfservice access to the underlying data. Meeting any one of these demands is manageable. Meeting all three simultaneously requires a fundamentally different data architecture than most GPs have today.

This is the link between the LP Pressure Index and the Scaling Constraints Map. The LP demands documented here are, in effect, an external forcing function on the same cross-system data integration problem identified as the #1 scaling constraint. GPs cannot deliver faster, bespoke, ondemand reporting without clean, normalized, continuously updated data pipelines.

The ODD Burden: In Their Own Words

We asked respondents to describe the hardest recurring LP/ODD request to satisfy. The openended responses reveal a consistent theme: bespoke demands that resist systematization.

> “Each ODD is a different template and definitions of required fields are always different.”
>
> — CFO, Multi-Strategy Platform

> “Side letter report where data is needed from portfolio management system, accounting system, and spreadsheets which don’t have common identifiers.”
>
> — Senior Operations Leader, $50B+ Platform

> “Supporting datasets and documentation: full transaction-level cash flows, portfolio positionlevel data extract, capital account data feed, look-through company financials, ESG metric datasets.”
>
> — Head of Data, Large-Scale Manager

> “Mark-to-market and timely valuations. Every LP wants it on their schedule.”
>
> — Head of Operations, Direct Lending

> “Frequency and volume of requests. It’s the sheer throughput that breaks us.”
>
> — CTO, Mid-Market Platform

From The Interviews: Why LP Pressure Is Structural

The interviews revealed that LP pressure operates through multiple mechanisms, not all of which are visible in the survey data. At larger platforms, the pressure is self-reinforcing: competitive positioning creates promises that become operational mandates.

> “We’re out there promising things. Daily NAV, real-time reporting, data room access so LPs can see the underlying company financials. That’s how you attract and differentiate. But once you’ve made that promise, the pressure to actually deliver it flows back onto the front office. And then an LP sees another manager offering the same thing, comes to us and says can you do that too. The promises compound.”
>
> — Product & Strategy Leader, $50B+ Platform

A Head of Credit Product at a major technology platform offered a more structural view. In his framing, the reporting pressure is a symptom of a deeper shift in how LPs are asserting themselves:

> "LPs are starting to walk with their dollars toward managers who will give them an easier time. If you just need access to an asset class and one manager is going to cost you an extra five to ten FTEs just to process their data because they're inflexible on format, you're going to move your commitment elsewhere."
>
> — Head of Credit Product, Global Technology Platform

At smaller firms, the dynamic is different. An emerging manager building from scratch was direct about how LP pressure actually works in practice. In his telling, institutional LPs do not coach GPs on what to upgrade. They run a red-flag checklist and move on if anything is missing.

> "The easiest thing for an LP to do is run their red list. If anyone hits any of those flags, they're out. Then they sort by returns, by track record, by pedigree, and the top one or two float to the top. They don't coach you on what to improve. They just move to the next one."
>
> — CFO, Emerging Manager (Pre-Launch)

A mid-market Managing Director described a third mechanism: competitive benchmarking. Many of his firm's LPs are also investors in competitor funds. If another manager provides something his firm does not, those LPs will ask for it. The bar keeps rising because someone else already raised it.

One concrete data point from the interviews that deserves specific mention: side letter agreements at some firms now require LP estimates within 10 business days for private credit portfolios. That timeline compresses the entire valuation workflow and puts strain on every upstream process.

74%	37%	#1
REPORT LP/ODD PRESSURE HAS INCREASED	SAY INCREASE IS "SIGNIFICANT"	FASTER REPORTING IS TOP LP DEMAND



A panellist speaking at the inaugural Summit in London

Credits: The Private Markets Forum Team

We asked: which LP or allocator requirement is the biggest driver of your infrastructure modernization? The results show a market being reshaped by three closely ranked demands.

LP-Driven Modernization Priorities (Weighted Ranking)

LP REQUIREMENT	WEIGHTED	#1	#2	#3
Faster / more frequent reporting	50	8	9	8
Bespoke reporting formats / templates	45	9	6	6
Real-time or on-demand data access	40	7	6	7
More granular portfolio data (loan-level)	29	5	6	2
Investment guidelines / mandate compliance	16	3	1	5
Valuation / pricing governance	16	2	3	4
Cybersecurity / operational resilience	15	2	4	1
Replicating books and records	10	1	2	3
ODD depth (controls, policies, evidence)	7	1	1	2

74% of respondents report that LP/ODD pressure has increased over the past two years. More than one in three say the increase has been significant. This is an accelerating trend.

Pressure Trajectory

LP/ODD PRESSURE TREND	COUNT	SHARE
Significantly increased	14	37%
Somewhat increased	14	37%
Stayed about the same	9	24%
N/A	1	3%
All respondents	38	100%

The Modernization Trajectory

Where is the industry headed? This section maps what operators have changed in the past 12–18 months, what they plan to prioritize next, and what's driving those decisions. The picture is an industry in active transformation, led by data platform investments and increasingly by AI deployment at production scale.

I
Scaling constraints

II
LP pressure

III
Modernization

IV
Build list

V
At scale

From The Interviews: How Operators Think About AI

The interviews surfaced sharper frameworks for AI deployment than the survey data alone can capture. The most pointed came from a strategy leader at a $50B+ platform, who drew a clear line between firms that are succeeding with AI and those that are not.

> "The companies that have done successful AI implementation go an inch wide and a mile deep. They fully automate one specific workflow that they've already mastered manually. Then you put an agent on it. The mistake is thinking you can just drop in an LLM and it'll figure things out."
>
> — Product & Strategy Leader, $50B+ Platform

His framework for the build-versus-buy question in the AI era was equally direct: build what is bespoke and differentiating, buy what someone else has already solved. The interesting shift is that AI has made building so cheap that the old calculus is changing. But the prerequisite for all of it, in his view, is structured data in a warehouse. Without that foundation, AI deployment is premature.

On the human-in-the-loop question, a Managing Director at a mid-market firm was clear about where the line sits. His firm uses AI to process volume at the front end of the deal pipeline, filtering thousands of potential deals down to the ones worth serious attention. But no final investment decision will ever be made purely off AI output. The tool filters and prioritizes. A human being makes the final call every time. That boundary, in his view, is non-negotiable in private credit.

That same respondent was candid about the noise level in the AI vendor market. He receives cold outreach weekly from AI products promising to automate some part of his process.
His observation:

if he believed everything he was being pitched, his firm could let AI run the entire business. The challenge is not finding AI products. It is evaluating which ones actually meet the firm's standards.

45%	79%	61%
SCALING AUM AS PRIMARY TRIGGER	INCREASING TECH BUDGETS	AI IN PRODUCTION (1+ WORKFLOWS)

Respondents identified the infrastructure changes their firms have made in the past 12–18 months. Data platform implementation and data workflow automation lead by a wide margin, each cited by 45% of respondents.

What Firms Have Changed (Last 12–18 Months)

CHANGE MADE	COUNT	SHARE
Implemented data platform (warehouse/lakehouse)	17	45%
Automated data workflows (ingestion, monitoring, exceptions)	17	45%
Introduced AI/ML in production	13	34%
Cyber / resilience program improvements	10	26%
Strengthened reconciliation / accounting controls	9	24%
Made outsourcing/insourcing/co-sourcing decision	9	24%
Added/changed core portfolio/loan system	9	24%
Upgraded LP reporting process / portal	7	18%

Looking ahead, data workflow automation holds the top position. AI deployment and data platform investment follow closely. The industry's forward agenda is converging on a clear stack: unified data, automated workflows, AI-augmented processes.

Priorities for the Next 12–18 Months (Weighted)

PRIORITY	WEIGHTED	TOP 1	TOP 2
Automated data workflows	28	9	10
Data platform (warehouse/lakehouse)	19	8	3
AI/ML in production	18	7	4
Reconciliation / accounting controls	15	3	9
LP reporting process / portal	14	6	2
Core portfolio/loan system	8	2	4
Outsourcing/insourcing decision	8	2	4
Cyber / resilience	4	1	2

Methodology: Weighted score assigns 2 points for Top 1 priority and 1 point for Top 2.

What's driving the next wave of investment? Scaling AUM remains the dominant trigger, but multistrategy complexity has risen sharply as a modernization driver (21%), reflecting the industry's expansion beyond direct lending into ABF, structured credit, and multi-asset platforms.

Primary Triggers for Modernization

TRIGGER	COUNT	SHARE
Scaling AUM / deal volume	17	45%
Adding strategies / multi-strategy complexity	8	21%
Entering / scaling wealth channels	6	16%
Cost reduction / efficiency push	4	11%
LP/ODD requirements	2	5%
Competitive pressure (peers are ahead)	1	3%
All respondents	**38**	**100%**

The AI adoption curve in private credit has moved faster than many anticipated. 61% of respondents now have AI deployed in production for at least one workflow. One in four run AI across multiple workflows. The "exploring" phase is over for the majority of the market.

AI/Automation: From Pilot to Production

AI JOURNEY STAGE	COUNT	SHARE
In production for multiple workflows	10	26%
In production for 1–2 workflows	13	34%
Piloting in limited use cases	8	21%
Exploring / evaluating vendors	6	16%
Not exploring yet	1	3%
All respondents	**38**	**100%**

Document extraction is the consensus entry point and the most widely deployed AI use case across the sample. But the ambition extends further: investment memo drafting is already the second most common AI workflow, and covenant tracking and monitoring are in active deployment.

Where AI Is Being Deployed

AI WORKFLOW (MULTI-SELECT)	FIRMS USING	SHARE
Document extraction / financial spreading	26	68%
Investment memo drafting	17	45%
LP reporting / data extraction	11	29%
Covenant tracking / compliance checking	7	18%
Monitoring alerts / exception triage	7	18%

When asked where they see the single biggest opportunity for AI in the application stack, the answers extend well beyond current deployment. Underwriting and credit analysis (24%) and covenant compliance (21%) rank close behind data ingestion (29%), signaling where investment will concentrate next.

Biggest AI Opportunity Area

BIGGEST AI OPPORTUNITY	COUNT	SHARE
Data ingestion / document extraction	11	29%
Underwriting / credit analysis	9	24%
Covenant compliance / legal review	8	21%
Portfolio monitoring / exception management	5	13%
Risk analytics / valuation	1	3%
LP reporting / investor communications	1	3%

The hybrid model—combining vendor solutions with internal customization—is the dominant deployment approach (39%). This suggests that off-the-shelf AI tools are insufficient for the nuances of private credit workflows. Firms need the ability to adapt and control. The 26% building in-house using enterprise LLM APIs (OpenAI, Anthropic) reflects the technical depth of larger platforms.

Deployment Approach

APPROACH	COUNT	SHARE
Hybrid (vendor + internal customization)	15	39%
Built in-house using enterprise LLM APIs	10	26%
Purchased vendor solution with AI built-in	10	26%
Haven't successfully deployed yet	2	5%

Governance is tightening alongside deployment. Half of respondents operate under a guided posture with policies in place and vendor approval required. 26% describe their posture as restrictive. The market has moved past the "move fast and break things" phase into structured, policy-driven adoption.

AI Governance

GOVERNANCE POSTURE	COUNT	SHARE
Guided (policies, vendor approval required)	19	50%
Restrictive (formal approval, limited use cases)	10	26%
Open (minimal restrictions, experiment encouraged)	5	13%
No formal policy yet	2	5%
Blocked (AI tools not currently permitted)	1	3%

The Build List

The final pillar surfaces what doesn't exist yet, or doesn't exist well enough. These are the infrastructure gaps the market needs filled. The data here comes from three open-ended questions that together map the industry's unmet needs, interoperability pain points, and demand for peer intelligence.

I

Scaling constraints

II

LP pressure

III

Modernization

IV

Build list

V

At scale

From The Interviews: The Data Model As Foundation

The interviews reinforced the unified data model finding with operator experience. A Credit Controller at a firm that built its credit business from scratch within a larger PE platform described attending a Private Funds CFO conference where the question "if you had to start over, what would you do first?" came up repeatedly. The answer was near-universal:

> "A unified data model with a data warehouse where all position and accounting data from various sources flows into one place, all the relationships are built, everything speaks to each other. I left that conference thinking: I think we got that one right. It's probably the hardest thing to undo as you scale, because everything builds on top of it."
>
> — Credit Controller, PE Platform with Nascent Credit Strategy

A Head of Credit Product at a major technology platform offered the most structural version of the build list answer. His wand wave was not a technology feature but a market structure change: lifecycle activity in private credit (paydowns, amendments, agent notices) is still processed through PDFs that people then scrape with LLMs. His vision is that a paydown should be captured as a digital record at the moment it is created, then disseminated directly to systems of record as a transaction.

> "In 2026, in an AI-first era, that makes no sense. The paydown should be captured as a digital record at the moment it's created. Not: create it digitally, print it to paper, send it as a PDF, and then reconstruct the digital record on the receiving end."
>
> — Head of Credit Product, Global Technology Platform

His point was that individual firm-level technology improvements will always be capped in their impact if the underlying market rails do not change. That change requires ecosystem participants (technology providers, data providers, agent banks, lenders) to coordinate. It will not happen through individual firm action alone.



Panellists in session at the Private Markets Technology Summit

Credits: The Private Markets Forum Team



A point made from the panel

Credits: The Private Markets Forum Team

45%	32%	32%
WANT A UNIFIED CROSS-STRATEGY	WANT COMMON PRIVATE CREDIT IDENTIFIERS	WANT TO SEE PEERS' TECHNOLOGY STACKS

We asked: if you could wave a wand and solve one operational problem, what would it be? The responses cluster tightly. The unified data model is the clear winner, cited by nearly half the sample. This is the single strongest signal in the entire survey.

"Wave a Wand": The #1 Operational Problem to Solve

PROBLEM TO SOLVE	COUNT	SHARE
A unified data model across strategies and systems	17	45%
Clean, standardized borrower data ingestion at scale	6	16%
Monitoring + exception management without headcount growth	4	11%
LP reporting / ODD response that's fast and repeatable	3	8%
Wealth channel operations at scale	3	8%
ABF collateral / borrowing base verification	2	5%
Reconciliation that is low-touch and cross-system	2	5%
Covenant tracking that is reliable and auditable	1	3%
All respondents	38	100%

The dominance of the unified data model response (45%) reflects a fundamental architectural deficit. Most private credit platforms operate with fragmented data spread across multiple systems, strategies, and formats. The direct lending team uses one system. The ABF team uses another. The accounting team uses a third. And the reporting team stitches them together manually.

Until this problem is solved, every downstream function—reporting, risk, compliance, monitoring— will continue to require manual intervention to bridge the gaps. This is why cross-system integration appears as the #1 weighted scaling constraint, the #3 manual workaround area, and the dominant "wand" answer. The industry is describing the same problem from three different angles.

We asked which data standard or interoperability problem respondents would most like solved. The responses identify three distinct layers of the standards problem.

Interoperability and Standards Gaps

STANDARD / INTEROPERABILITY NEED	COUNT	SHARE
Common identifiers for private credit assets	12	32%
Standardized LP reporting template	10	26%
Common API standards for system integration	8	21%
Standardized borrower / loan tape format	6	16%

The call for common identifiers (32%) addresses a structural gap. Unlike public securities with CUSIPs or ISINs, private credit assets lack a universal identifier. This makes automated tracking, settlement, and cross-platform reconciliation structurally difficult. The LSTA's push for FIGI adoption in private credit is a step forward, but the gap remains wide.

The demand for a standardized LP reporting template (26%) mirrors the ODD burden documented in Section II. One respondent captured it precisely: the challenge is not the lack of a standard. It is that every LP continues to send their own template regardless of what standards exist. ILPA's 2.0 templates represent progress, but respondents indicate they remain one more format rather than a replacement.

The final question surfaces latent demand for benchmarking and peer intelligence. These responses carry direct implications for the ongoing value of this research program.

What Operators Want to Learn from Peers

PEER INTELLIGENCE NEED	COUNT	SHARE
Technology stack decisions (what systems peers use)	12	32%
What 'good' looks like (benchmarks / maturity model)	11	29%
Vendor vs. build decisions (what worked)	6	16%
Implementation pitfalls / change management	4	11%
Org model / headcount ratios	3	8%

The top two responses are closely linked: operators want to know what systems their peers are running (32%) and what "good" looks like as a benchmark (29%). Together, 61% of respondents are asking for operational intelligence that does not currently exist in private credit. The industry benchmarks available in public markets—risk management maturity frameworks, technology spend ratios, staffing models—have no equivalent here.

The interviews confirmed this demand in the most direct terms. A Managing Director at a mid-market firm described how he currently makes technology adoption decisions: by calling peers and competitors to ask what they are using.

> "If I had access to a survey showing that 50% of private credit firms are using a given product, that single data point would make decisions significantly easier. The market is so crowded with competing products that any real data on what's actually being adopted would be enormously helpful."
>
> — Managing Director, Mid-Market Multi-Strategy Firm

He went further, noting that there is no Forrester or Gartner equivalent for private credit infrastructure. No independent research presence covers the space. If one existed, he said, there would be clear demand for it.

What Breaks At Scale: Segmented Analysis

The aggregate findings tell a clear story. But infrastructure challenges are not uniform across the industry. Firms at different stages of growth face different constraints, feel different LP pressures, and adopt technology at different speeds. This section segments the data by AUM tier to surface the patterns that only emerge when you look beneath the averages.

I

Scaling constraints

II

LP pressure

III

Modernization

IV

Build list

V

At scale

AUM Tier Definitions

TIER	DEFINITION
Emerging (<$5B)	Growth-stage firms building foundational infrastructure.
Mid-Market ($5–$30B)	Scaling firms hitting integration complexity for the first time.
Large Platform ($30B+)	Multi-strategy platforms managing legacy systems at institutional scale.

The top scaling constraints shift markedly across firm sizes. Each tier faces a fundamentally different version of the infrastructure challenge.

Where It Breaks: Constraints by Tier

RANK	EMERGING (<$5B)	MID-MARKET ($5–$30B)	LARGE PLATFORM ($30B+)
#1	Talent (hiring/retaining)	Talent + Reconciliation (tied)	LP reporting
#2	Cross-system integration	Market data availability	Cross-system integration
#3	Portfolio monitoring	Data ingestion	Portfolio monitoring

The pattern tells a clear story. Emerging firms are constrained by people. They lack the headcount to run operations at even moderate scale. Mid-market firms are constrained by process. Reconciliation, data ingestion, and market data gaps reflect the growing pains of adding complexity without adequate tooling. Large platforms are constrained by architecture. LP reporting and crosssystem integration dominate because these firms have multiple systems across multiple strategies that were never designed to work together.

Notably, talent drops from the #1 constraint at emerging firms to a non-factor for large platforms. This is not because large firms have solved the talent problem. It is because at scale, the architectural constraints become so dominant that they overshadow even chronic understaffing.

LP pressure is not uniform. It intensifies sharply with firm size, and the nature of the pressure shifts.

LP Pressure Intensity by Tier

METRIC	EMERGING (<$5B)	MID-MARKET ($5–$30B)	LARGE PLATFORM ($30B+)
Pressure increased	67%	70%	79%
"Significantly" increased	22%	30%	47%
Top LP driver	Faster reporting	Granular data + Cyber	Bespoke templates
#2 LP driver	Bespoke templates	Real-time data access	Real-time data access

The gradient is striking. Nearly half of large platforms report a significant increase in LP/ODD pressure, compared to roughly one in five emerging managers. But the more actionable insight is in what LPs are asking for. Emerging managers face a straightforward demand: report faster. Large platforms face a more complex challenge: deliver bespoke, real-time, self-service data access across diverse investor types. The infrastructure required to serve these two demands is fundamentally different.

One of the more surprising findings in the segmented data: AI adoption does not follow a simple size gradient. Emerging firms are deploying AI at nearly the same rate as large platforms, but the approach is radically different.

AI Adoption: Not a Straight Line

METRIC	EMERGING (<$5B)	MID-MARKET ($5–$30B)	LARGE PLATFORM ($30B+)
AI in production	78%	40%	63%
Multiple workflows	22%	10%	37%
Dominant approach	Built in-house (44%)	Vendor solution (60%)	Hybrid (58%)
Budget increasing	89%	80%	74%

The emerging-firm cohort defies expectations. 78% have AI in production, the highest rate in the sample. They are disproportionately building in-house using enterprise LLM APIs, suggesting that smaller, tech-forward teams are moving faster precisely because they lack legacy systems to integrate around. They are building AI-native workflows from scratch.

One emerging manager in the interview cohort captured this dynamic precisely. He compared the situation to banking infrastructure: South Africa skipped checks entirely and went straight to electronic fund transfers because they started later. The same principle applies to private credit firms launching today.

> "Every firm, every project, every organization that starts later gets the benefit of building at the current technology level. It would make no sense for me to build an antiquated data workflow and then modernize it in two years. There's no legacy. There's no technical debt. I get to start where the industry is today."
>
> — CFO, Emerging Manager (Pre-Launch)

Mid-market firms are the laggards, with only 40% in production. This may reflect the worst of both worlds: large enough to face complexity but not large enough to fund dedicated AI engineering teams. Their reliance on vendor solutions (60%) supports this interpretation.

Large platforms deploy the hybrid model (58%), combining vendor tools with internal customization. They have the engineering resources to adapt off-the-shelf AI to their specific workflows, but the integration challenge with legacy systems slows deployment relative to greenfield emerging firms.

Core system dissatisfaction is universal, but the response differs. Emerging firms are the least satisfied (average 2.4/5) yet build at a lower rate. Large platforms are marginally more satisfied (2.9/5) but build at the highest rate, suggesting that large firms have both the resources and the necessity to work around inadequate vendor solutions.

System Satisfaction and the Build Response

METRIC	EMERGING (<$5B)	MID-MARKET ($5–$30B)	LARGE PLATFORM ($30B+)
Core system satisfaction	2.4 / 5	3.0 / 5	2.9 / 5
Built internal tools	67%	60%	79%
Top manual workaround	Valuation / mark-to-market	Data ingestion / spreading	3-way tie: Ingestion, LP reporting, Data stitching

We also examined whether multi-strategy firms (running 3+ strategies) differ from more focused firms on the data integration constraint. The answer is yes, but the gap is narrower than expected.

Strategy-Based View: Multi-Strategy Complexity

METRIC	MULTI-STRATEGY (N=22)	FOCUSED (N=16)
Cross-system integration in top 3	59%	44%

59% of multi-strategy firms rank cross-system data integration in their top three constraints, compared to 44% of focused firms. The gap confirms that strategy complexity compounds the integration challenge, but the fact that nearly half of focused firms also rank it highly indicates that the problem is pervasive regardless of strategy count. Even a single-strategy firm running direct lending with separate systems for origination, portfolio management, and reporting faces integration pain.

Perhaps the most telling finding in the segmented analysis: the “wave a wand” answer is consistent across all three tiers. A unified data model is the #1 response regardless of firm size.

The Unified Data Model: Universal Demand

METRIC	EMERGING (<$5B)	MID-MARKET ($5–$30B)	LARGE PLATFORM ($30B+)
“Unified data model”	33%	50%	47%

This universality is significant. It means the demand for a unified data layer is not a large-firm luxury or a scaling-stage bottleneck. It is a foundational gap across the entire industry. Emerging firms want it because they are building from scratch and see the opportunity to get it right early. Large platforms want it because they are drowning in the consequences of not having it. The market opportunity for solutions that address this need spans the full AUM spectrum.

Conclusion: The Infrastructure Imperative

The survey data paints a consistent picture: private credit's infrastructure is not keeping pace with its ambition. The industry is growing at 1.5–2x. LP demands are intensifying. Multi-strategy complexity is compounding. And the operational systems that underpin most platforms were built for a smaller, simpler era.

The good news is that the industry knows it. Technology budgets are rising. AI is moving from exploration to production. Data platforms are being built. But the core architectural challenge— creating a unified, normalized data layer that can serve multiple strategies, multiple investor types, and multiple reporting demands simultaneously—remains the industry's most critical unsolved problem.

The firms that solve this first will be the platforms that scale. The vendors that build to this need will find a market starving for solutions. And the industry standards that emerge—common identifiers, standardized loan tapes, interoperable APIs—will be the foundation on which the next generation of private credit infrastructure is built.

PILLAR	KEY FINDING	HEADLINE METRIC
Scaling Constraints	Cross-system data integration is the #1 weighted constraint. 71% build internal tools because the market is underserved. Core system satisfaction: 2.8/5.	53% rank integration in top 3
LP Pressure Index	LPs are pushing from document delivery to data delivery. Faster reporting, bespoke templates, and real-time access are the top three demands.	74% report rising pressure
Modernization Trajectory	Data platforms and workflow automation lead recent and planned investment. AI has crossed from pilot to production for 61% of firms.	61% have AI in production
Build List	Unified data model is the dominant #1 need (45%). Common identifiers and peer benchmarking are the top standards and intelligence gaps.	45% want unified data model
Segmented Analysis	Emerging firms break on people, mid-market on process, large platforms on architecture. AI adoption is non-linear: emerging firms lead at 78%.	People → Process → Architecture

Appendix: Methodology

Survey Design

The 2026 Private Credit Infrastructure Survey was designed as a structured, quantitative instrument targeting operational and technology leaders at private credit managers. The survey covers firm context, scaling constraints, manual workaround concentration, LP pressure drivers, modernization trajectory, AI adoption, and open-ended gap identification.

Question design prioritized forced-ranking approaches over "select all that apply" formats for prioritization questions, enabling weighted scoring analysis that reveals true prioritization rather than general acknowledgment. All ranking questions use a top-3 format with explicit ordinal selection.

Data Collection

The survey was deployed via Typeform and distributed through The Private Markets Forum's network of private credit operators, with targeted outreach to COOs, CTOs, CIOs, Heads of Data, and other operational and technology leadership. Survey design was stress-tested with senior industry operators prior to launch. This report reflects responses from 38 senior operators collected between January and March 2026. The sample was built through targeted outreach — not broad distribution — with the explicit goal of reaching the decision-makers at the largest and most operationally complex platforms in the market. 42% of respondents manage $50B+ in private credit assets. Findings are further enriched by follow-up qualitative interviews with select operators conducted while the survey was still in the field. These interviews inform the narrative analysis throughout this report.

Analysis Approach

Ranking questions are analyzed using weighted scoring (3 points for #1 selection, 2 for #2, 1 for #3) to surface true prioritization. Multi-select and categorical questions are reported as simple frequency distributions. Open-ended responses are thematically coded and reported as aggregated categories with representative anonymized quotations. All data is aggregated and anonymized. No individual firm or respondent is identified in this report.

Sample Composition

DIMENSION	DISTRIBUTION
AUM	42% $50B+ | 21% <$1B | 16% $5–$15B | 11% $15–$30B | 11% Other
Primary Role	47% CTO/Tech | 16% MD/Partner | 11% Head of Data | 26% Other Ops/C-Suite
Growth Trajectory	50% 1.25–2x | 24% 2x+ | 11% <1.25x | 11% Uncertain | 5% Flat
Strategies	66% ABF | 63% Direct Lending | 58% Multi-Strategy | 58% Structured Credit | 47% BDCs
Investor Base	76% Institutional | 55% Wealth Channel | 47% Insurance | 47% Family Office

The Private
Markets Forum